

WHODUNIT? A car torched during protests against Waqf law in Murshidabad, Apr. 11

PTI

ity of local harmony in the absence of provocation—that forms a major strand in the report of a 17-member fact-finding team on the violence in West Bengal. The other strand is its obverse: sinister signs of orchestration.

"Certain findings made us question the spontaneity of it all. The way eight boats were hired in Parlalpur to ferry families from Murshidabad, for instance," says Rangta Munshi, one of those who extensively toured riot sites on April 18-19, interviewing victims, eyewitnesses and local authorities. The team, drawn from five civil society groups, contrasts acts of violence and state inaction with the baseline of local amity these interrupted to conclude it was "not a spontaneous riot, but a calculated campaign of disruption, enabled by administrative silence".

Takeaways

- **"Not a spontaneous riot," says a fact-finding team after touring ground zero in Bengal**
- **Governor Bose also visits sites, controversially hints at "constitutional options"**

BATTLE OF NARRATIVES

In the poisoned smog of mistrust, the team's report challenges the narrative of mutual hatred that was reflected in a different sort of report. Governor C.V. Ananda Bose, who also visited the riot sites on April 18-19, wrote to the Centre on May 3, suggesting—controversially—that it may consider "constitutional options" to restore confidence in the rule of law in Bengal. The phrase hints at Article 356: President's rule. On May 5, CM Mamata Banerjee visited Murshidabad, and vowed to expose the conspirators, seeking immunity from blame for her regime. The fact-finding team, though, saw a curious pattern, beginning with the first spark on April 11: stone-pelting on a Dhuliyan rally, allegedly from houses associated with a Hindutva outfit. Soon, as shops were sacked, close by was a police station that did nothing.

As solidarity shone in patches, the report suggests, only deliberate orchestration could explain the scale and speed of violence. Eyewitnesses in villages spoke of masked men—some dressed as BSF or police—raiding Muslim homes at night. In Betbona and Jafrabad, where two Hindus were killed, it was again huge mobs of masked attackers on the rampage. Police again arrived long after, despite being stationed minutes away.

Politics will take over: the narrative of local antipathies not harming its goals. On the ground, the report suggests, that's not entirely organic. ■

By **Jumana Shah**

WHEN A PATIENT AT Ahmedabad's Vadilal Sarabhai Hospital (VSH) approached Congress corporator Rajshri Kesari over a missing Rs 3,000—'payment' for participating in a clinical trial—neither could have imagined the scale of what lay beneath.

It turned out that between 2021 and 2024, over 500 patients may have been unwittingly turned into guinea pigs. Misled into thinking they were receiving routine treatment, they were allegedly subjected to unauthorised clinical drug trials in at least nine departments of the nearly century-old hospital, with the errant doctors in cahoots with 52 pharmaceutical companies.

TRIALS AND ERRORS

Some Rs 17-20 crore is said to have changed hands, as patients got enrolled in trials for drugs related to diabetes, arthritis, skin conditions, even a rare genetic disorder. No approval from a registered Institutional Ethics Committee (IEC) was allegedly taken, nor

